

POLICY: CALL CONDUCT & ESCALATION

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Department	Call Center Operations

1. Scope

Applies to all Tier 1 agents on every inbound call. Compliance is mandatory for QA scoring. This document consolidates: Call Handling (CS-POL-2025-01), De-escalation (CS-POL-2025-05), and Escalation Routing (OPS-POL-2025-03).

2. Rules

Severity: CRITICAL = immediate violation. MAJOR = scored failure. MINOR = coaching trigger.

2.1 Call Opening

CS-RULE-001	Agent must greet with: 'Thank you for calling NexaLink Telecommunications Broadband and Support. My name is [Name]. Who do I have the pleasure of speaking with today?'	MAJOR
CS-RULE-002	Agent must state recording notification immediately after greeting if not played by IVR: 'This call may be recorded for quality assurance and training purposes.'	CRITICAL
CS-RULE-003	Agent must acknowledge the customer's stated reason before proceeding: 'I understand you are calling regarding [issue]. I can certainly help you with that.'	MAJOR

2.2 Identity Verification

CS-RULE-004	Agent must verify the customer using exactly 3 of the following 5 identifiers before accessing any account data: (1) Full account holder name, (2) Account number, (3) Security PIN, (4) Last 4 digits of payment method, (5) Last 4 of SSN/National ID where applicable.	CRITICAL
CS-RULE-005	No account data, billing information, plan details, or account changes may be disclosed or processed before successful 3-of-5 verification is confirmed.	CRITICAL
CS-RULE-006	Third-party callers must be listed as Authorized Users in the CRM. No changes may be made for unlisted third parties under any circumstances.	CRITICAL

2.3 Communication Standards

CS-RULE-007	Agent must respond to any customer statement or question within 3 seconds. Dead air exceeding 5 seconds without verbal acknowledgment is a violation.	MINOR
CS-RULE-008	Agent must not interrupt the customer. Maximum of 2 interruptions per call is permitted only to redirect a wandering conversation. Zero interruptions is the standard.	MINOR
CS-RULE-009	During any silent task (e.g. running a line test), agent must re-engage within 10 seconds: 'I am still here with you; [task] is in progress. Thank you for your patience.'	MINOR
CS-RULE-010	Agent talk ratio must not exceed 40% of total call duration. Agents must not deliver unbroken technical monologues.	MINOR

2.4 De-escalation

CS-RULE-011	When a customer is angry or frustrated, agent must apply A.C.E.S. in order: Acknowledge → Clarify → Empathize → Solve. Skipping Acknowledge or jumping directly to Solve is a violation.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-012	The following phrases are forbidden in any customer interaction: 'Calm down' / 'There is nothing I can do' / 'That is our policy' / 'I do not know' / 'That is not my department'.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-013	Agent must adapt tone to the customer's emotional state. Agent must never match an elevated customer's volume. Speak at a lower pitch and slower pace for angry customers.	MAJOR

2.5 Escalation Triggers & Routing

Trigger	Required Action	Target Tier
Customer requests supervisor or manager	One de-escalation attempt, then transfer	Tier 3
Customer remains angry/frustrated > 2 minutes after A.C.E.S.	Transfer	Tier 3
Customer states intent to cancel or switch providers	Acknowledge + warm transfer	Tier 3
Billing dispute > \$200	Document and transfer	Tier 2
Customer has called 3+ times for same unresolved issue	Apologize and transfer	Tier 3
Legal threat or regulatory body mentioned	Do not argue; transfer immediately	Tier 4
Agent abuse / personal threats (after 3-strike warning)	Disconnect or transfer	Tier 3/4
Compliance error occurred during call (e.g. missed verification)	Transfer for correction	Tier 2
Infrastructure outage / fiber cut / tower failure confirmed	Inform customer and file ticket	Tier 2

CS-RULE-014	Escalation transfers must be warm: brief hold max 2 minutes, receiving party briefed on issue and customer sentiment, customer introduced to new agent. Cold transfer permitted only if queue exceeds 5 minutes or during a declared outage.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-015	If target tier is unavailable, a callback ticket must be created. SLA: High priority (outage/supervisor) = 2 hours. Medium (complex tech/billing) = 4 hours. Low (general) = 8 hours.	MAJOR

2.6 Abuse & Harassment

CS-RULE-016	Personal attacks, slurs, sexual harassment, or physical threats trigger the 3-Strike Protocol. Strike 1: warning. Strike 2: final warning. Strike 3: call termination with stated reason. Swearing at the situation is not abuse; swearing at the agent is.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-017	If a customer threatens self-harm or harm to others, agent must keep the line open (mute) and signal supervisor immediately. Do not disconnect.	CRITICAL

2.7 Resolution & Closing

CS-RULE-018	Before closing, agent must explain the root cause of the issue to the customer.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-019	Agent must deliver a resolution summary in the format: Issue + Fix + Follow-Up Actions, before closing.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-020	Agent must ask 'Is there anything else I can help you with today?' before closing every call.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-021	Agent must provide the Case Reference Number and offer the post-call survey. Exception: do not offer survey if the call ended in a completed cancellation.	MAJOR

2.8 Documentation

CS-RULE-022	Case notes must be completed and saved within 5 minutes of call end. Required fields: verification method, issue reported, troubleshooting steps taken, resolution status, customer sentiment.	MAJOR
CS-RULE-023	Case notes must never contain full card numbers, full SSN, PINs, passwords, or security answers. Mask all sensitive identifiers.	CRITICAL